BEYOND CHIAVARI · FREE PLANNING KIT

Baby and Bridal Shower Planning Kit

Everything a host needs to plan a baby or bridal shower: who hosts, timeline, games, food amounts, budget, and thank-you tracking.

A shower is a few hours of warmth, good food, and a little silliness for someone you love. This kit helps you divide the work, build a timeline, plan the menu, and keep track of every gift and thank-you note. It works for baby showers, bridal showers, and couples showers alike.

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Chairs, tables, linens, tents and more across Chicagoland, on one quote.

PART 1

Who Hosts and Who Pays

- Traditionally, close friends or family host the shower, not the guest of honor. Many hosts now share the work and the cost.
- For a bridal shower, the maid of honor and bridesmaids often host, with help from the mothers or grandmothers.
- For a baby shower, a sister, best friend, coworker, or grandparent often hosts. A co-host group is common.
- Agree on a total budget before anyone buys anything, and put each host's contribution in writing.
- Split jobs by strength: one host handles invitations, one handles food, one handles decor, one handles games.
- Check with the guest of honor about the guest list, theme, and any off-limits topics before you plan.
- Ask the guest of honor's family for key names and addresses, but let the guest of honor approve the final list.
- Include co-workers, neighbors, and extended family only if the guest of honor wants them there.
- Decide early whether partners and kids are invited, and say so clearly on the invitation.
- For a surprise shower, appoint one person as the decoy to get the guest of honor to the venue.

PART 2

Shower Timeline

Most showers happen 4 to 8 weeks before the wedding or 4 to 8 weeks before the due date. Spring and early summer weekends fill up fast in the Chicago area.

8 to 10 weeks out

- [ ] Choose the date with the guest of honor and key guests in mind.
- [ ] Set the budget and decide who is hosting.
- [ ] Draft the guest list and get addresses.
- [ ] Pick a venue: home, restaurant, brunch spot, garden, or rented hall.
- [ ] Choose a theme and color palette.
- [ ] Check the registry and decide on a gift expectation, such as books for the baby or recipes for the bride.

6 weeks out

- [ ] Send invitations by mail or email with an RSVP date.
- [ ] Include the registry details and any dress code.
- [ ] Reserve rentals: tables, chairs, linens, plates, glassware, and a tent if outdoors.
- [ ] Book the caterer, baker, or order from a local restaurant.
- [ ] Hire a photographer for an hour or assign a friend.

4 weeks out

- [ ] Plan games and activities and order any supplies.
- [ ] Order decor: banners, balloons, flowers, and signs.
- [ ] Plan the menu and drinks, including non-alcoholic options.
- [ ] Order or make favors.
- [ ] Arrange for a gift table and a place to store gifts.

2 weeks out

- [ ] Follow up on RSVPs.
- [ ] Give the final headcount to the caterer and rental company.
- [ ] Prepare the gift-tracking sheet and thank-you list.
- [ ] Plan the seating, including a special chair for the guest of honor.
- [ ] Create a playlist.
- [ ] Confirm the weather plan for outdoor showers.

1 week out

- [ ] Confirm deliveries and vendor arrival times.
- [ ] Buy non-perishable food and supplies.
- [ ] Print games, signs, and name tags.
- [ ] Assign helpers: greeters, gift recorders, photographers, cleanup crew.
- [ ] Prepare a small thank-you note kit with pens and cards.

Day before and day of

- [ ] Set up tables, chairs, and decor.
- [ ] Prepare make-ahead dishes and chill beverages.
- [ ] Receive and inspect rental deliveries.
- [ ] Set out food, games, and gifts table before guests arrive.
- [ ] Welcome guests with a drink and a name tag.
- [ ] Take photos of the guest of honor with each guest.

After the shower

- [ ] Count and load gifts in the guest of honor's car.
- [ ] Return or arrange pickup of rentals.
- [ ] Pay vendors and send tips.
- [ ] Send the gift-tracking sheet to the guest of honor.
- [ ] Send guests a thank-you message and photos.
- [ ] Remind the guest of honor to send thank-you notes within a month or two.

PART 3

Shower Planning Checklists

INVITATIONS AND GUESTS

- [ ] Confirm the guest list with the guest of honor.
- [ ] Include the date, time, address, RSVP, and host contact on the invitation.
- [ ] Add registry details and any theme or dress code.
- [ ] Note whether the shower is for women only, a couples shower, or open to all.
- [ ] Send a reminder text to guests a few days before.
- [ ] Plan accessible seating and parking for older guests.

VENUE AND SETUP

- [ ] Reserve the venue and confirm the setup time.
- [ ] Arrange tables for dining, gifts, desserts, and games.
- [ ] Set up a photo backdrop or corner.
- [ ] Create a welcome sign and signage for food stations.
- [ ] Place decorations at eye level and at the entrance.
- [ ] Put out seating for older guests and plenty of napkins.

RENTAL ITEMS

- [ ] Order one chair per guest plus a few extras.
- [ ] Choose table sizes: 60 in rounds for seated lunch, 6 ft rectangles for buffets.
- [ ] Order linens that match the theme.
- [ ] Rent plates, flatware, glasses, and serving pieces to cut down on waste.
- [ ] Add a drink dispenser or beverage tub.
- [ ] Rent a tent and heaters or fans for outdoor showers.

DAY-OF SUPPLIES

- [ ] Scissors, tape, and a trash bag for gift wrap.
- [ ] Gift recorder pad and pens.
- [ ] Camera or phone charger.
- [ ] Extra napkins, wet wipes, and a first aid kit.
- [ ] Tissues for happy tears.
- [ ] Containers for leftovers.

PART 4

Games and Activities

Choose two or three. Many guests prefer fewer games and more conversation.

BABY SHOWER

- [ ] Guess the baby food flavors.
- [ ] Baby bingo while the guest of honor opens gifts.
- [ ] Advice cards and wishes for the baby.
- [ ] Guess the due date or birth weight.
- [ ] Decorate onesies with fabric markers.
- [ ] Diaper-raffle ticket with each gift of diapers or wipes.
- [ ] Book instead of a card: each guest signs a book for baby's first library.

BRIDAL SHOWER

- [ ] How well do you know the bride trivia.
- [ ] Recipe cards for the couple's first meals.
- [ ] Memory jar with stories and advice.
- [ ] Wedding dress paper craft or toilet-paper veil contest.
- [ ] Mimosa bar or tea tasting.
- [ ] Scavenger hunt in the venue.
- [ ] Candle or flower arranging as a group activity.

BOTH

- [ ] Guest book or photo wall.
- [ ] Photo booth with props.
- [ ] Word-scramble or word-search with themed words.
- [ ] Door prizes for the winners.
- [ ] Slideshow of the guest of honor through the years.
- [ ] A group toast.

PART 5

Menu Amounts

For a 2 to 3 hour brunch or lunch shower. Increase if serving a full dinner. Amounts are rough planning numbers.

Item	Per person	15 guests	30 guests	50 guests
Finger sandwiches or small bites	4 to 6 pieces	75 pieces	150 pieces	250 pieces
Salad	1 cup	15 cups	30 cups	50 cups
Quiche, frittata, or main dish	1 slice or serving	2 large	4 large	7 large
Fruit platter or fruit cups	1/2 cup	8 cups	15 cups	25 cups
Pastries or mini muffins	1.5	22	45	75
Cake	1 slice	1 quarter sheet	1 half sheet	1 half sheet plus extra
Cupcakes or cookies	1.5 to 2	30	60	100
Mimosas or champagne	2	30 glasses (about 5 bottles)	60 glasses (about 10 bottles)	100 glasses (about 17 bottles)
Non-alcoholic drinks	2 to 3	40	80	130
Coffee and tea	1 to 2 cups	25 cups	50 cups	80 cups

PART 6

Shower Budget Split

A rough guide for a seated brunch or lunch shower. Costs vary a lot across Chicago and the suburbs.



Category	Share	Your budget: $_____	Tip
Venue or rentals	25%	$_____	Hosting at home can save most of this line, but you may still need tables, chairs, and linens.
Food and beverage	40%	$_____	Brunch is often less expensive than dinner. Order desserts from a local baker.
Decor and flowers	12%	$_____	Choose a few high-impact items rather than many small ones.
Invitations and stationery	5%	$_____	Digital invitations are fine for most showers.
Games and prizes	5%	$_____	Small prizes work well. Use items the guests will actually use.
Favors	5%	$_____	Edible or plant favors are well-loved and easy to pack.
Photography	3%	$_____	Ask a friend, or hire a photographer for one hour.

Category	Share	Your budget: $_____	Tip
☐ Contingency	5%	$_____	Set this aside for extra guests, weather changes, or forgotten items.

PART 7

Gift-Opening and Thank-You Tracker

Make several copies. Record each gift as it is opened so thank-you notes are quick and personal.

GUEST NAME AND ADDRESS

GIFT DESCRIPTION

GIFT CARD AMOUNT, IF ANY

STORE FOR RETURNS OR EXCHANGES

THANK-YOU NOTE WRITTEN (DATE)

THANK-YOU NOTE MAILED (DATE)

GIFT RECORDER NAME

TOTAL NUMBER OF GIFTS RECEIVED

GIFTS NEEDING A SEPARATE THANK-YOU FOR A GROUP GIFT

GIFTS TO EXCHANGE OR RETURN

GUESTS WHO SENT GIFTS BUT DID NOT ATTEND

HOSTS TO THANK IN PERSON

PART 8

Shower Planning Worksheet

GUEST OF HONOR

HOSTS AND PHONE NUMBERS

DATE AND TIME

VENUE AND ADDRESS

THEME AND COLORS

GUEST COUNT (EXPECTED AND CONFIRMED)

TOTAL BUDGET

MENU AND CATERER

CAKE OR DESSERT ORDER

GAMES CHOSEN

RENTAL DELIVERY WINDOW

PHOTOGRAPHER OR PHOTO PLAN

GIFT TABLE HELPERS

WEATHER OR BACKUP PLAN

NEXT STEP

Get every rental on one quote

Pick chairs, tables, linens, dinnerware, tents and decor from Chicago-area rental companies and see prices as you build your list at beyondchiavari.com/quote. Want a second set of eyes on your plan? Book a free planning call at beyondchiavari.com/book.

Planning rules of thumb only. Confirm counts, rules and timing with your venue and vendors. © Beyond Chiavari. Free to print and share for personal planning.